



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

does free
will explain
all evil?

The most prominent reply to Mackie's argument focuses
on the good of free will:

For every evil in the world, there
is some greater good which even
God could not have brought
about without allowing that evil.

The free will defense

Because free will is a good, a wholly good being might wish for others to have free will. But it is impossible to both give free will to creatures and stop them from using that free will to do evil. (To do the latter would be to take away, to that extent, their free will.) Hence a wholly good creature might well not eliminate evil which it was within its power to eliminate, when doing so would be an infringement on the free will of the creature causing the evil.

The problem, as we've seen, is that in the case of some evils it is hard to see what the corresponding good could be.

This response to the argument fairly obviates two assumptions.

The first is that we really do have free will.

The second is that having free will is a really good thing.

Are these assumptions plausible?

The most prominent attempt to answer this question
focuses on the good of free will:

The key question is what this could be.

on the good of free will:

The most prominent reply to Mackie's argument focuses

The problem, as we've seen, is that in the case of some evils it is hard to

see what the corresponding good could be.

The most prominent attempt to answer this question

focused on the good of free will:

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

Summing up so far: we have seen that free will promises to explain how

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good



the ability
to harm others
is a great good



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does free
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A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free
will explain
all evil?

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

does free
will explain
any evil?